



Ages 11 to 14

When Someone at Home Hurts You

What abuse at home can look like, why it's never your fault, and how to get help. For all students.

Before You Read This guide talks about children being hurt or treated badly at home.

This guide is about what to do if an adult at home hurts you, or makes you feel scared or unsafe. Some of it might feel close to home. That's OK.

- Read it in bits, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline** is free and confidential. You can call 0800 1111 any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.

If you or someone else is in danger right now, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

Home should be a place where you feel safe. Most adults look after the children they live with. But sometimes an adult at home hurts a child, or makes them feel frightened, worthless or alone. This guide explains what that can look like, and how to get help.

- It can happen in **any family**, whatever the family's background, money, religion or country.
- The person might be a **parent, step-parent, carer, relative, guardian** or another adult you live with or stay with.
- If it's happening to you, **it is not your fault**. Not because of your marks, your behaviour, or anything else.

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust:** a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.

- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away**.
- If you're **scared to go home today**, tell an adult at school **before the end of the school day**.
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999**.
- **Childline**: 0800 1111, free, any time.

What Do the Words Mean?

Physical abuse

When an adult hurts your body on purpose: hitting, kicking, shaking, or hitting you with something.

Emotional abuse

When an adult keeps making you feel worthless, scared or unloved, for example by shouting, threatening or calling you names.

Neglect

When the adults who look after you keep not giving you what you need, like food, warm clothes, care when you're ill, or keeping you safe.

Sexual abuse

When someone touches you in a way that isn't OK, or makes you do or watch sexual things. It is never OK.

Trusted adult

An adult you feel safe with: a teacher, tutor, coach, house parent, school nurse or counsellor.

These are the four kinds of abuse that schools look out for. They can happen together.

Rules at Home, or Something Not OK?

Rules and Consequences

- Adults at home can set rules, like bedtimes, homework and screen time
- They can be disappointed about marks, and tell you so
- They can take away your phone or say no to things
- You can make mistakes and still feel safe at home

Not OK

- Being hit, kicked, shaken, or hit with a belt or anything else
- Being hurt so that it leaves marks or bruises
- Being so scared of an adult that you dread going home
- Being told you're worthless, stupid or unwanted, again and again
- Being told to keep it secret, or that you'll be punished for telling

If something on the "not OK" list is happening, **tell a trusted adult**. You don't have to be sure it's "bad enough", and **you don't have to wait for it to happen again**.

It's Never Your Fault

- **Bad marks are not a reason for anyone to hurt you.** Nor is forgetting homework, arguing back, or breaking something.
- Adults are responsible for how they behave, even when they're stressed, angry or disappointed.
- Some adults say, "This is how I was brought up." You can love your family and still need them to stop hurting you.
- If someone told you it's your fault, or that you deserved it, **that isn't true**.

How It Can Feel

- Scared, sad, angry or confused, sometimes all at once
- Worried about tests or reports, because of what might happen at home
- Wanting to protect your family, or worried about getting someone into trouble
- Ashamed, or like you have to hide marks or bruises
- Nervous that no one will believe you

All of these feelings are normal. None of them means you should stay quiet. Adults at school want to help.

How to Tell

- **Pick someone you trust:** any adult at school. It doesn't have to be the safeguarding team; whoever you tell will pass it on.
- **Pick a moment:** after a lesson, at break, in the nurse's room, or at the boarding house.
- **Find the words:** "Can I talk to you about something at home?" is enough to start. You could also write it down and hand it over.
- **You don't have to show anyone your body or your injuries.** You can just tell them.
- If the first adult doesn't help, **tell someone else.** Keep trying until someone listens.
- **Childline** (0800 1111) can help you work out what to say.

What Happens When You Tell

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with someone you trust.** Behind them is a team whose job is to make sure you get the right help.
- The adult will listen and take what you say seriously.
- **They won't just ring home.** The safeguarding team will think carefully first about how to keep you safe. They may need to talk to other people whose job is to help children, like a social worker.
- If an adult is worried about your safety, they will share the concern with the school's safeguarding team. They will explain what happens next and involve you as much as possible in decisions about keeping you safe. They won't promise to keep it secret.
- Adults who work with young people are allowed to share information that helps keep children safe without asking your permission. They only share what is needed, and only with the people who need to know. They will tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put someone in danger, and they will listen to what you think.
- You will be kept informed and asked what you need.

If You're Worried About Going Home

- Tell the adult: "I'm scared to go home." They will take it seriously.
- The safeguarding team will make a plan with other people whose job is to keep children safe, and will try to do this before the end of the school day.

- They can't always promise what will happen, but they will tell you what's going on and listen to what you think.

Your Views Matter

- You'll be asked what you think and what you're worried about.
- Sometimes adults have to make decisions to keep you safe, even if you don't agree. They should explain why.
- You won't be in trouble for telling.

If You're Worried About a Friend: RESPOND

Children often tell a friend first. If a friend tells you they're being hurt at home, here's what you can do. You don't have to fix it: your job is to get them to an adult.

You Lead (R, E, S)

R

Recognise

Notice the signs.

- Does your friend seem scared of going home, or really worried about tests?
- Have they got marks they don't want to talk about, or have they changed?
- You don't need to be sure to do something

E

Engage

Listen.

- Find a quiet moment: "You don't seem yourself. Are you OK?"
- Listen. Don't ask lots of questions, and don't ask to see any marks



Support

Be kind.

- "It's not your fault. I'm glad you told me."
- "Let's tell someone who can help. I'll come with you."

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Stop and think.

- Don't talk to their parents or family, or post about it
- Don't promise to keep it a secret: they need an adult's help
- You don't have to find out more, keep watch or collect proof. That's the adults' job

Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Show them there's help.

- Tell your friend a trusted adult can help, and offer to go with them



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- Tell a trusted adult **the same day**, even if your friend asks you not to. Tell your friend you're going to, if you can
- If your friend is scared to go home, tell an adult **before the end of the school day**
- That isn't getting them into trouble. It's how they get help



Document

Adults write it down.

- The adult will make a record. You just need to tell them what you saw and heard

If you see a friend being hurt or threatened, **get an adult straight away**, or call 999 if someone is in danger. Don't get in the middle yourself.



Staying Safe Online

- If you share a phone, tablet or computer with other people at home, **they may be able to see what you've looked at**.
- The Childline website has a **"Hide page" button** on every page, to leave quickly.
- Childline explains how to use **private browsing** and how to **clear your history**. These don't always work, for example if a device has monitoring software, so a school or library computer can be safer.
- Calls to Childline won't show up on most phone bills, but they may show in your phone's list of recent calls.
- Read more: Childline: cover your tracks.



Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"If I got bad marks, I deserved it"	Nobody deserves to be hurt. Bad marks are never a reason to hurt a child.
"It's normal in my family, so it's OK"	Families are different, but being hurt or made to feel scared at home is not OK, and you can get help.
"Telling will get my family into trouble"	Telling is about keeping you safe. Adults whose job is to help children will also think about what help your family needs.
"No one will believe me"	Adults at school are trained to listen and take you seriously. If one doesn't, tell another.
"I have to show someone my bruises"	You don't. Telling someone is enough.

If You Board

- **You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.**
- If you're worried about going home at the weekend or in the holidays, or about staying with a guardian, **tell a house parent before you go.**
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.
- You can always contact your family privately.
- If an adult at home is the person hurting you, tell a house parent or the DSL; they will help you stay safe when you are in touch with home.

Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor, a teacher, a coach, the school nurse, a counsellor, or a house parent if you board
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19):** 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **This is the place to start.** Childline: physical abuse
- **Shout:** text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk. This helpline is for adults who are worried about a child: a trusted adult could call it for you
- **Emergency:** call 999 if you or someone else is in danger right now

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

When Someone at Home Hurts You: Student Guide 6 - 11 to 14

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Contacts and figures checked September 2026 | Next review: September 2027